

2 March, 2026

CMCT 6535: Editorial Review of “The Librettists Who Wrote on Air”

Dear Aly,

Thank you for sharing your webtext, “The Librettists Who Wrote on Air,” with our workshop. The review group found your project to be a compelling and timely contribution, and the feedback below is offered formatively, in the spirit of helping you strengthen a piece that is already working in many important ways. The comments are organized around the four areas we use for webtext review: Contribution, Rhetoric and Design, Methodology, and Citations.

Contribution

Your reviewers agreed that the contribution is strong. The way you weave in broader cultural themes—particularly the play’s treatment of *bacha bazi*, and its treatment of homophobia—makes the stakes of your argument legible to audiences well beyond those already interested in this specific 2014 production. Your core thesis, that the play was written with very little regard for Afghan culture and limited research into that culture, is well supported and functions as a clear, guiding thread throughout the text.

Two areas could make the contribution even stronger. First, in the opening and closing passages, you might be more explicit about the exact academic or cultural conversation you are entering. Who are the interlocutors? What is the theoretical gap your analysis identifies? Naming that gap directly will help bookend your argument and signal where the work sits in the field. Second, pointing readers toward future research directions—where else might this intervention travel, and what questions remain open—would help situate the piece more fully within the scholarly community and give the conclusion a stronger sense of purpose.

Rhetoric and Design

The design of the webtext was praised. Reviewers noted that it is clean and professional, that typographic hierarchy is present, and that the use of negative space works effectively to guide the reader through the argument. The introduction does good work positioning the argument and giving the reader a sense of what to expect.

A few targeted improvements are worth considering. The font weight is currently quite light, which reduces the contrast between regular text, emphasized text (bold and italic), and headings. Increasing the weight—particularly on headings and any emphasized lines—would sharpen the typographic hierarchy and make the visual argument easier to follow at a glance. Reviewers also noticed that the navigation menu has an issue: clicking “Bibliography” causes the label to switch to “Essay,” and vice versa. That will need attention before the piece goes public, along with completing the remaining menu sections.

There was also a discussion about the placement of the introduction. Moving it to the index/home page—or placing an abstract there—could make the entry point to the webtext more immediately engaging and help orient readers before they dive deeper. This is worth experimenting with as you finalize the layout.

On media: reviewers appreciated that you are thinking carefully about a dedicated media tab, particularly given the sensitive nature of some content. Including a content warning at or near the entry to that section would be an important and reader-centered addition. Because this webtext is fundamentally about music and performance, there may also be an opportunity to incorporate audio—whether archival sound bites, excerpts from the production, or other audio artifacts—which could convey aspects of the subject that images alone cannot. A tool like SoundCite is worth exploring for embedding audio within the text itself. Finally, the reviewers thought the Edward Tufte CSS template (available on GitHub) could serve as useful inspiration for responsive, book-like layouts with marginal notes—a style that might suit your project’s tone and subject matter.

Methodology

Your combination of ethnographic and memory methodologies is intriguing, and the reviewers found the method of literary analysis—anchored by citations from scholars such as Edward Said and Nasser Al-Taei and grounded in postcolonial theories—to be well supported. The autoethnographic thread, particularly your reflection on family memory and your family’s lived experience, adds a distinctive and valuable dimension to the piece.

One area worth developing: the memory methodology, while compelling as described, could be made more legible in the design and structure of the webtext itself. If memory is a core method, the webtext might find ways to formally enact or reflect that—through fragmentary design elements, or through the way images and media are captioned and connected to the family history you describe. Reviewers noted that any use of family material requires care and consent, and that is entirely understandable. But to the extent that archival material is available—news clippings, documents tracing the reception of the production, or other public records—incorporating that into the media section could add weight to the memory work and give it an external anchor without requiring deeper disclosure. The goal would be to make the methodology feel as active in the form of the webtext as it is in the written argument.

Citations

The scholarly review draws from a range of voices, including both Western and non-Western scholars, which reviewers appreciated. The citation work is well supported, and the range of sources helps situate the argument across multiple traditions. As you revise, it is worth reviewing the full list with an eye toward inclusive citation practices—considering gender, race, disability, and the balance between open- and closed-access sources—to ensure the bibliography reflects the breadth of the field your work engages.

Overall, this is a promising and well-developed webtext. The argument is clear, the design is thoughtful, and the methodology is distinctive. The suggestions above are intended to help you refine what is already working and push the project to its full potential. We look forward to seeing how it develops.

Sincerely,

Dr. Rich Shivener